

Hyottoko

Dreaming. Otsuka woke from the drought at home, in his study. Felt as if he were lichen-encrusted stone. In the past, droughts were nothing—blank spaces in his memory, with only his surroundings as evidence for the passage of time. An arm shifted, a leg. He glanced behind himself before noticing the gentle inspiration, expiration of his chest. He imagined the burning in his abdomen as whisky tearing at his stomach lining with machete as if invasive flora. The sun caught the edge of the claymore on his wall. Then the pommel. How long had passed between edge of sword to pommel, he didn't know. But by this point, the lichen encasing him had relented, or at least as far as his movements had asked of it. Images, not unlike cotton candy dissolving in water, lightly colored and sweetened his mind. There was proprioception, and there was also perception, the understanding—and differentiation—between reality and dream. The drought blankness, gone. Sensation of dreamless sleep was present, yet images still greeted him like children tugging at a father fresh home from work.

As the images dissolved, more and more, his heart sped up as he started to read what the images were pointing towards. Not of dream, of *deja vu*, or of reality. Whatever that word “reality” could possibly mean anymore under the regime of the droughts. Squirming in his seat, his heart rate to began to plateau. Began to turn his cheeks red, as if he were now some sort of animal triggering a defense mechanism. If only people reacted to embarrassment the way predators did to prey.

He wondered at that idea of defense mechanisms for a while, to stall his shame and maybe defeat it that way. Meandered through the thoughts of the animal kingdom's equivalents to shame. In some contexts, he thought, the red color would trick the predator into thinking the prey was poisonous or venomous. Almost like one of ours wearing designer clothing or accessories, in an effort to be left alone or the opposite—depending on who's asking. In some environments, like that of the US, shame almost sort of attracted people whereas in others, it could be repellent, abhorrent even. Attracted people, yes. Like a sneeze. If you sneeze in a room full of strangers, no one will feel obligated to you. Yet a group of people surrounding you, acquaintances will rush to hand you your blessing. Grimace or sneer at your tears, yes, but still try to comfort you, if a little nosily. Maybe shame isn't so similar to predation, Otsuka thought. He dropped the subject with himself.